

MD Lite



A little space to read — and write.

A lightweight, native Markdown reader and editor for macOS. Built with SwiftUI, AppKit, TextKit, and Swift Markdown. The whole app is under 4 MB.

[📄 Latest release](#) [📄 Build status](#) [📄 MIT license](#) [📄 macOS 14 or later](#)

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Three ways to look at a document

Mode	Shortcut	What it is
Reading	⌘1	The finished document: typography, tables, images, diagrams.
Editor	⌘2	Write with the formatting in view. Markers such as ** or # only appear on the line you are editing.
Source	⌘3	Plain Markdown with syntax colors.

Split	⌘4	Source on the left, the finished page on the right, scrolling together. Drag the divider to resize.
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Press **⌘E** to jump between reading and editing. Undo and redo (**⌘Z**, **⇧⌘Z**) work across every edit, including checking a task in the reading view. Files you open save themselves as you type; new notes ask where to go the first time you press **⌘S**.

GitHub Flavored Markdown

MD Lite follows the [GFM specification](#) and renders what GitHub renders:

- Headings (ATX and Setext) with GitHub-style anchors, paragraphs, line breaks, and thematic breaks
- Emphasis, strong, strikethrough, inline code, and backslash escapes
- Inline, reference, and autolinks, including extended autolinks (`www.`, `https://`, e-mail)
- Ordered, nested, and task lists — click a checkbox to check it
- Tables with column alignment, rendered as native TextKit tables
- Fenced and indented code blocks with syntax highlighting and a copy button
- Block quotes and GitHub alerts (`> [!NOTE]`, `[!TIP]`, `[!IMPORTANT]`, `[!WARNING]`, `[!CAUTION]`)
- Raw HTML as it appears in real READMEs: `<p align="center">`, `<img width>`, `<picture>`, `<details>`, `<kbd>`, `<sub>`, `<sup>`, HTML tables, and comments. Script-like tags are filtered as GFM requires.
- [Mermaid](#) diagrams in ````mermaid` blocks, drawn offline
- YAML front matter

Tabs, panes, and working folders

Each window has its own tab strip. **⌘T** opens a clean tab you can drop a file on, or open, create, or paste a document into; every tab keeps its own undo history and scroll position. Drag a tab or a file from Finder or the sidebar onto a

document to see where it will land: the left or right half opens it in a side-by-side pane, the middle opens it as a tab there. **⌘] / ⌘[** switch tabs, **⌘← / ⌘→** move a tab between panes, and **⌘W** closes a pane, moving its tabs to the other one.

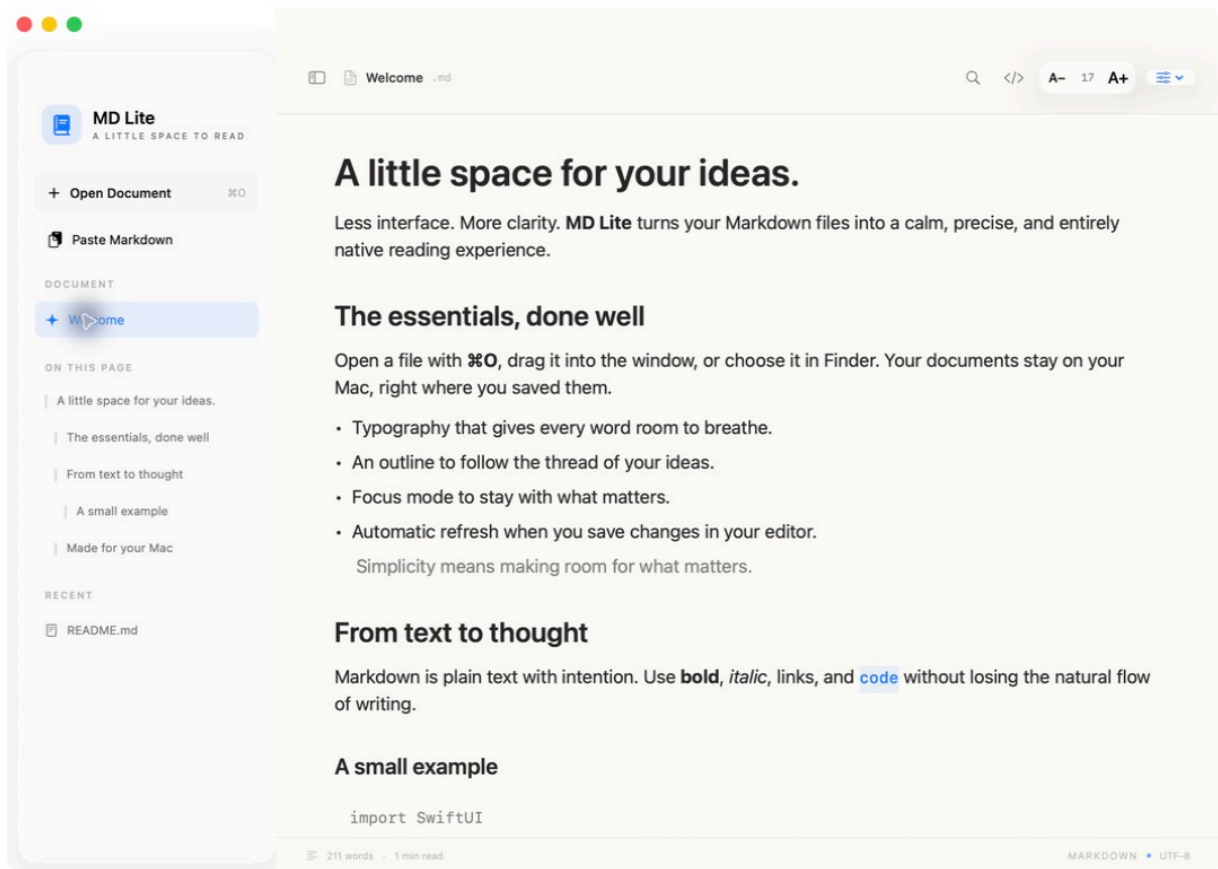
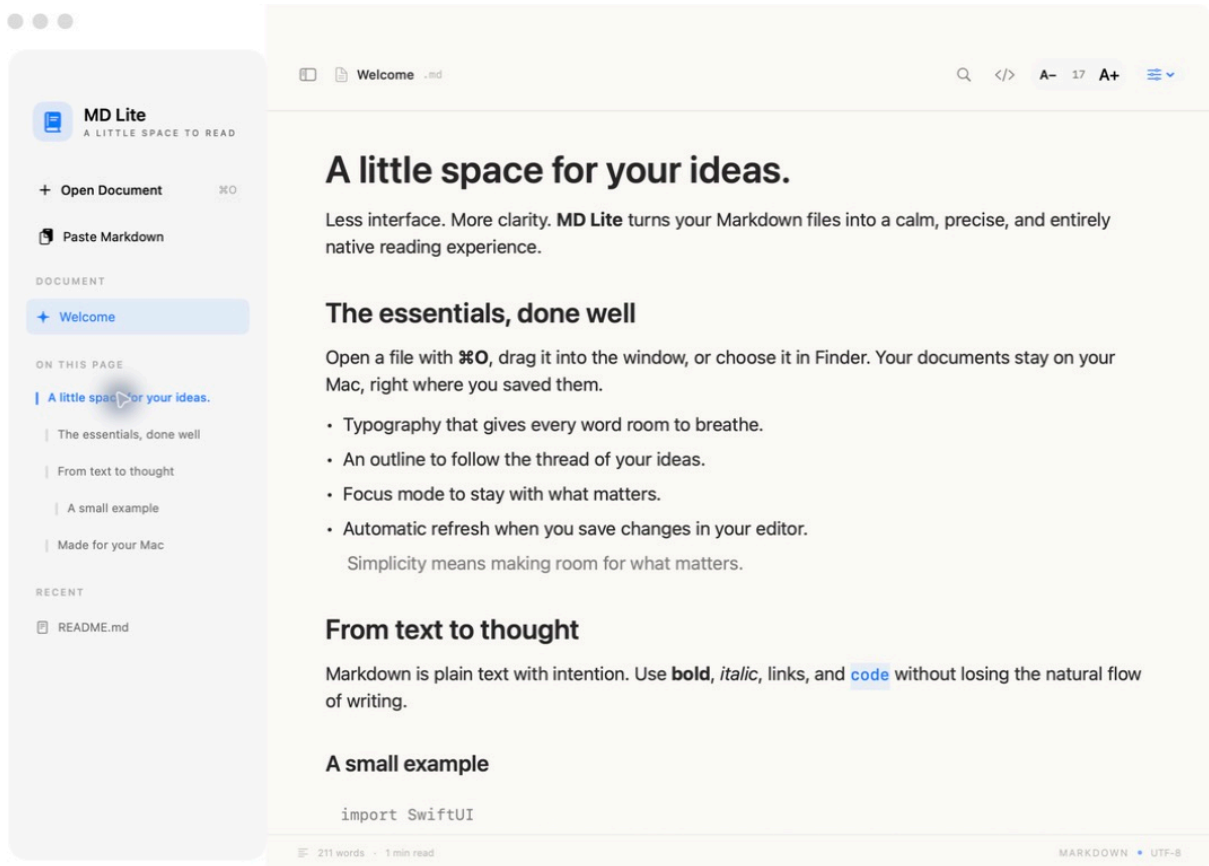
⌘W always closes the innermost thing first: a sheet or popover, then About or Settings, then the tab (and its pane when it was the last one); the app stays open. Open a whole folder with **⌘O** (or drop it on the window) to browse its Markdown files as a tree in the sidebar; hidden and generated folders such as `node_modules` are skipped, and **⌘**-click opens a file in a new tab. Settings open with **⌘,**.

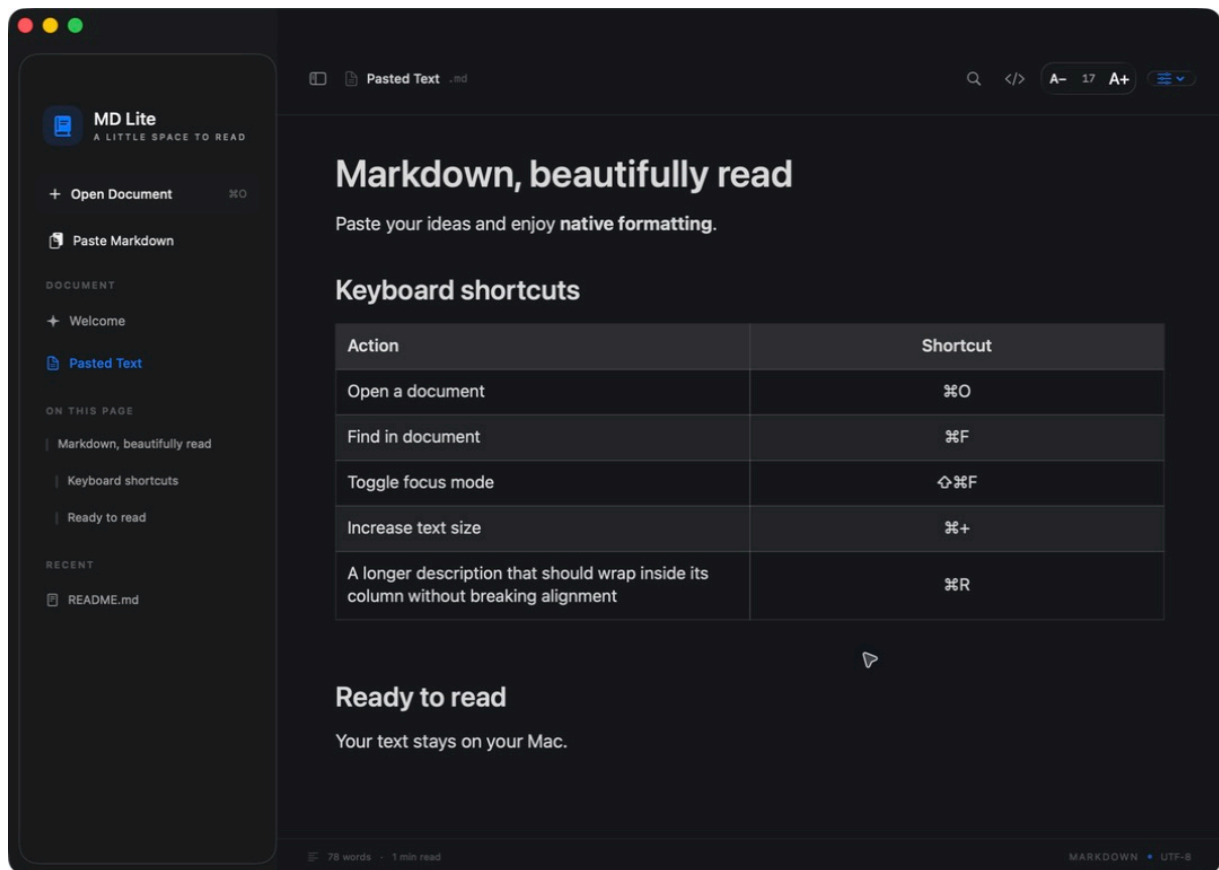
Right-click a tab or any file in the sidebar to open it in a new tab or pane, save a copy, duplicate it, export it as HTML or PDF, print it, add it to Favorites, give it Finder tags and colors, reveal it in Finder, or copy its path. Hover a file to see its full path, or click the tab title for a breadcrumb.

A calm navigator

The sidebar outlines the document as a collapsible tree, follows you while you scroll, filters long outlines, and jumps with **⌘↑ / ⌘↓**. Hide it with **⌘S** (or **⌘**), or press **⌘F** for focus mode, which hides everything but the text until you press it again (or Esc). Choose a narrow, normal, wide, or full text column in Reading Preferences.

Screenshots





Download

Requires **macOS 14 Sonoma or later** and **Apple silicon**.

1. Download the latest [DMG from GitHub Releases](#).
2. Drag **MD Lite** into **Applications**.
3. Open a `.md` file from Finder or press **⌘O** inside the app.

Windows and Linux

Each release also ships **MD Lite for Windows** (MD-Lite-...-windows-x64-setup.exe, installs for the current user, no admin rights) and **MD Lite for Linux** (.AppImage and .deb). It is a separate, lightweight [Tauri](#) app in [desktop/](#) that uses the system WebView: the same GitHub Flavored Markdown, HTML, alerts, code highlighting, and Mermaid rendering; Reading, Editor, Source, and Split modes with undo; tabs; working folders; autosave; the outline navigator; and `Ctrl` versions of the shortcuts. The Windows installer is not code-signed yet, so SmartScreen may ask you to confirm the first launch.

To make MD Lite open Markdown files on double-click, choose **MD Lite ▶ Use**

MD Lite for .md Files... — a short guide walks you through it. **Check for Updates...** in the same menu compares your version with the latest GitHub release.

Shortcuts

Press **⌘**/ inside the app to see them all.

Action	Shortcut
Reading / Editor / Source / Split	⌘1 · ⌘2 · ⌘3 · ⌘4
Toggle reading and editing	⌘E
Show or hide the sidebar	⌘S · ⌘\
Focus mode	⌘F
New tab · Close · Settings	⌘T · ⌘W · ⌘,
Next / previous tab · Close pane	⌘] · ⌘[· ⌘W
Move tab to the left / right pane	⌘← · ⌘→
New window	⌘N
New note · Open · Open folder	⌘N · ⌘O · ⌘O
Save · Save As	⌘S · ⌘S
Undo · Redo	⌘Z · ⌘Z
Find · Find next · Find previous	⌘F · ⌘G · ⌘G
Bold · Italic · Strikethrough · Inline code · Link	⌘B · ⌘I · ⌘X · ⌘K · ⌘K
Heading 1–3 · Body text	⌘1–3 · ⌘0
List · Numbered list · Task list · Quote	⌘7 · ⌘9 · ⌘L · ⌘'
Code block · Table · Divider	⌘M · ⌘T · ⌘–
Continue a list · Indent · Outdent	↩ · → · ⌘→
Previous / next heading	⌘↑ · ⌘↓
Increase / reset / decrease text	⌘+ · ⌘0 · ⌘–

Paste and read clipboard Markdown	⇧⌘V
Reload from disk · Print	⌘R · ⌘P
Keyboard shortcuts	⌘/

Build from source

Use Xcode 26 or later. The package targets macOS 14 and uses Swift 5.9 or later.

```
sh
```

```
git clone https://github.com/glozahn/md-lite.git
cd md-lite
swift test
./scripts/build-app.sh
open "dist/MD Lite.app"
```

The Windows and Linux app builds with Node 22 and Rust:

```
sh
```

```
cd desktop
npm install
npm run tauri build
```

GitHub Actions builds both platforms and attaches the installers to each release ([.github/workflows/desktop.yml](#)).

Create a DMG with `./scripts/build-dmg.sh`. `scripts/notarize-app.sh` signs with a Developer ID, notarizes, and staples the app; it reads your identity and App Store Connect key from environment variables or from a local, git-ignored `scripts/notarize.env` (see `scripts/notarize.env.example`). Certificates and private keys are never stored in the repository.

Privacy and weight

Documents stay on your Mac. Preferences and recent file paths are stored locally. MD Lite has no account, analytics, or telemetry.

- **Remote images** are blocked until you click **Show** (or enable *Always load remote images*).
- **Mermaid** runs offline in a hidden WebKit view with network access blocked. The library ships xz-compressed (about 750 KB) and is only loaded when a document contains a diagram.
- **Update checks** make one request to the GitHub Releases API, only when you ask or when you enable automatic checks.

Contributing

Issues and pull requests are welcome. For rendering issues, include a small Markdown example, your macOS version, and the expected result.

Credits and license

Inspired by [Markdown Guide](#), [QuickMD](#), and [Typora](#). MD Lite is an independent project and is not affiliated with them.

MD Lite is released under the [MIT License](#). Swift Markdown, cmark-gfm, and Mermaid retain their own licenses; their notices ship inside the application bundle.